General Sam Manekshaw, the then commandant of the Defence Services Staff College in Wellington.

As we've seen, Nehru's guidelines for the Forward Policy issued in November 1960 did not, at first, make any situational difference on the ground either in Ladakh or in NEFA, although excruciatingly detailed protest notes continued to be exchanged between the two countries. After May 1961, with the new command set-up in place—with Thapar as chief and Kaul as the CGS—there was a shift in the pattern of protests as the stakes were raised by the highly publicized Forward Policy. Though there was no major clash in the remaining months of 1961, there was enough activity in both Ladakh and NEFA for the Chinese to give a grim warning in their note of 30 November 'that they would have every reason to send troops across the McMahon Line and enter the vast area between the crest of the Himalayas and the southern foot'.

Meanwhile Nehru continued to put on a brave front. At times it seemed that his statements were all about assuaging the Indian Parliament and the media, which all was well under his stewardship. In October 1959, after the incident in Ladakh where ten Indians had been killed and Karam Singh brainwashed, Nehru had declared in Parliament: 'I can tell the House that at no time since our Independence have our defences been in better condition and finer fettle…' At the same time Nehru was careful to say that India should only operate in areas that were not disputed. It was no secret that he never expected the Chinese to expand the conflict beyond the odd border clash here and there. The state of affairs at the time was that while it appeared as though India had adopted a tough and non-compromising stand with China, in reality, with the few competent senior officers sidelined to make way for those who were rather despairingly referred to in army and governmental circles as the 'Kaul boys', the situation was very shaky.

At other levels, too, changes were taking place that would have far-reaching implications. Palit's successor in 7 Infantry Brigade, Brigadier Ranbir Singh, developed acute asthma that necessitated his immediate removal from Tawang. This created a problem for the MS, Major General Moti Sagar, who had to find an officer best suited to replace Ranbir Singh. Running into Brigadier John Dalvi at the Feroz Shah Kotla Stadium in mid-December where India was playing the third test match against Ted Dexter's MCC, Moti Sagar asked Dalvi if he would consider taking on the responsibility. At the time, Dalvi was on leave in Delhi, for he was posted